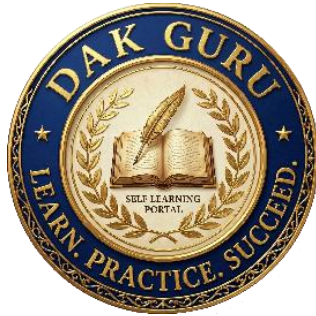




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HANDBOOK ON PHILATELY

A Complete, Updated Study Reference

For LDCE — Inspector of Posts (IP) & PS Group 'B' Departmental Examinations

Revised & updated edition

DISCLAIMER

This Handbook is a study aid compiled by **Dak Guru (www.dakguru.com)** for candidates preparing for the LDCE Inspector of Posts (IP) and PS Group 'B' examinations. It is based on the Department of Posts' *Handbook on Philately* and allied rules, orders and notifications. Explanatory notes and clarifications have been added to aid understanding.

Statutory and factual content has been checked against the latest publicly available primary sources and updated where the earlier position had changed (for example, the shift from the IPC to the **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023**, from Sales Tax/CST to **GST**, and the **Post Office Act, 2023**). Such changes are highlighted in shaded **UPDATE** boxes with the source and date so that currency can be independently judged.

Fees, rates, quotas and monetary limits are governed by Directorate circulars that are revised from time to time; the figures reproduced here are indicative and **must be confirmed against the latest orders in force** before being relied upon officially or in an examination requiring the current figure. Dak Guru is not an official publication of the Department of Posts and accepts no liability for any error or omission. In case of any conflict, the **original rule, order or gazette notification shall prevail**.



How to Use this Handbook

This edition keeps the full substance of the Department of Posts' *Handbook on Philately* and lays it out for easy study. Rule numbers have been retained so that you can cross-refer to the official handbook. Two kinds of highlighted boxes appear throughout:

- **UPDATE boxes** (blue) flag a place where the law or a factual position has changed since the handbook was written. Each box states the current position, the source and the date so you can verify it.
- **Note boxes** (amber) give a plain-language explanation, a memory aid, or a caution about figures that are revised by circular from time to time.

NOTE — ABOUT FIGURES

Monetary figures (fees, deposits, quotas, charges) are fixed by Directorate circulars and are revised periodically. The amounts printed here are those stated in the handbook and are indicative for concept-learning. Always confirm the current figure from the latest order before quoting it as the operative amount.

Currency & Update Notes (Summary)

The following changes have been verified against primary/authoritative sources and are carried into the relevant chapters. This page is a quick index of what has changed.

Topic	Current position	Source & date
Fictitious stamps offence (Rule 76)	IPC Section 263-A is repealed; the offence is now Section 186 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023. Substance is the same (fine up to Rs. 200).	BNS 2023 (Act 45 of 2023); in force 1 Jul 2024; IPC–BNS comparative tables
Sales Tax / Central Sales Tax (Rule 85)	Subsumed into GST from 1 Jul 2017. Stamps of current/new issue used for postage (HS 4907) are treated akin to money; collectible items fall under HS 9704. Confirm exact GST rate from the current CBIC rate notification.	101st Constitutional Amendment; CGST/IGST/SGST Acts 2017 (w.e.f. 1 Jul 2017)
Postal law framework	The Indian Post Office Act, 1898 is repealed and replaced by the Post Office	Post Office Act 2023 (Act 43 of 2023); Gazette S.O. 2352(E) dated 17 Jun 2024

Topic	Current position	Source & date
	Act, 2023 (in force 18 Jun 2024). Penal provisions were removed from postal law.	
Antiquities & Art Treasures Act, 1972 (Rule 86)	Remains the governing law. Thresholds unchanged: antiquity = at least 100 years; manuscripts/records = at least 75 years.	Act 52 of 1972 (in force from 5 Apr 1976); ASI, Ministry of Culture
Customs on stamps (Rule 86)	ITC(HS) heading structure (4907 / 9704) broadly continues. The '25% of face value' duty figure should be confirmed against the current Customs Tariff, as rates are revised in the annual Finance Act.	Confirm against current Customs Tariff / DGFT ITC(HS) schedule
My Stamp	Personalised/Customised postage-stamp sheet (added). Launched at INDIPEX-2011; 12 stamps of Rs. 5 face value per sheet, Rs. 300/sheet.	India Post Philately portal, app.indiapost.gov.in/philately
Deen Dayal SPARSH Yojana	Philately scholarship for classes VI–IX (added). Launched 3 Nov 2017; Rs. 6,000 p.a. per awardee.	Department of Posts / PIB (2017 onwards)
Online philately / e-Post Office	Online sale of philatelic items and operation of Philatelic Deposit Accounts is now live (the handbook's 'it is likely' has been realised).	India Post philately portal / ePost Office

Chapter I – Definitions of Philatelic Terms

1. Postage Stamp

A postage stamp is, in essence, a **receipt of a specified value that pre-pays postage**. Beyond that everyday function it is a symbol of a nation's sovereignty and a tool to celebrate and promote a nation's heritage. As a collectible, its value often exceeds its actual postal (face) value.

2. Types of Postage Stamps

(a) Definitive Stamps

Definitive stamps are issued for **day-to-day postal needs** and are kept on sale for an **unlimited period**. They come in several denominations and are printed in very large numbers, and are deliberately designed to keep manufacture, storage and sale costs to a minimum. India has issued several definitive series on themes relevant to the country's heritage and progress. A definitive series is generally changed after about **5 years**.

(b) Commemorative Stamps

Stamps, covers or postal stationery issued to commemorate an **event, institution, theme, flora/fauna or personage** are called commemorative stamps. They are printed in limited numbers and sold for a limited period from philatelic bureaux/counters/authorised offices. Unlike definitives they are printed **only once**, so as to preserve their value as collectibles. They do not supersede the current definitive stamps and are mainly bought by philatelists, though they too can be used to pay postage.

(c) Special Stamps

Special stamps are thematic issues (flora, fauna, architecture, art, etc.) brought out **without commemorating any specific event**.

(d) Joint Issue of Stamps

A joint issue is the **simultaneous / agreed issue of two or more stamps by India and another country**, in consultation with each other. The essential steps are:

1. A country takes up the proposal directly with India Post, or through the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) or its Embassy/High Commission in India; India Post can likewise approach another country.
2. The proposal goes to the International Relations (IR) Division of the Department of Posts, which consults the MEA to check clearance and viability.

3. A draft Joint Agreement is drawn up with terms acceptable to both countries and their postal organisations; when agreed, it is signed by the respective heads of the Philately Division.
4. A common concept for the design is agreed (e.g. 'Endangered Marine Species', Indo-Philippines 2009), but each country depicts different species and the actual design varies.
5. Each country prints its own stamps and ancillary products (miniature sheets, FDCs, brochures) with its own denomination and inscription protocol.
6. Exchange of philatelic material, if any, follows the Joint Agreement.
7. Any release function in India follows the usual protocol but in consultation with MEA / the Embassy / High Commission; the IR Division is kept informed.
8. If an Indian delegation is invited abroad, the case is processed on merits under extant rules, in consultation with the concerned Divisions/Departments/Ministries.

3. Issue, Release & Presentation

Issue — a stamp issue may be a single stamp, a *se-tenant*, or a set of two or more stamps.

Issue Date — the date on which a stamp first goes on sale across the counter at a Post Office / Philatelic Bureau / Counter.

Release — the formal act of a dignitary releasing a stamp at a function organised by the proponent(s). There can be **only one** release function.

Presentation — one or more presentations may be held at different places on any date **on or after** the date of release.

4. First Day Cover (FDC)

An FDC is a cover bearing the newly issued stamp **franked with the special cancellation of the day of issue**, brought out along with a commemorative/special stamp and put on sale on the day of release. It may be sent through post on the first day or kept for a collection. FDCs may also be brought out on the issue/release of definitive stamps.

5. Brochure

Whenever a commemorative/special stamp is issued, a publicity **brochure (information sheet)** is also brought out. It carries a brief write-up on the subject, the design, and the technical data of the stamp, and names the designers of the stamp, the FDC and the cancellation.

6. Cancellation Cachet

A cancellation cachet is a **cancellation device** (usually a hand stamp) impressed on a cover to mark the date of a special event — important occasions, personages, inaugural flights, expeditions, etc. It may also be applied through a mechanical device for neat cancellation. The cachets are withdrawn from the philatelic bureau **four weeks** after the occasion is over.

Cachets are procured by the Heads of Circles and supplied to all bureaux under their jurisdiction before the date of release. Manufacturing specifications:

1. Metal to be used: **Aluminium**.
2. Process of preparing blocks: **Photo-chemical**.
3. The aluminium block is fitted to a wooden board.
4. Handle size: length **11 cm** (excluding the portion inserted into the slot); diameter **1 inch**.
5. Wood for the handle: **Shisham**.
6. The handle must be fixed to the block firmly with nails or glue so it does not come off during handling.

NOTE

Any change in the cancellation will be notified separately.

7. Mint Sheet

A mint sheet is a **full sheet of unused stamps without any post mark**.

8. Issue Sheets

Stamps are supplied in **Issue Sheets** of generally **20 to 50** stamps, depending on stamp size. Anything below that number is, strictly, a *sheetlet*. For specification, the products carry names such as Miniature Sheet, Souvenir Sheet, Stamp Sheetlet and Stamp Booklet.

(i) Miniature Sheet

A sheetlet comprising **one or more postally valid stamps** to which the issue relates. Its size varies with the subject, the stamp size and the number of stamps. The area beyond the perforations extends or elaborates the theme and is complementary in nature. Its price may equal the face value of the stamp(s) or be more (as the Department decides on merit), in which case the denomination is shown on the sheet. A characteristic feature is the **zig-zag perforation** where two or more stamps are present, though this may not appear in every case. The release date may be the same as the stamp's or a specially appointed one.

(ii) Souvenir Sheet

Also a sheetlet like a miniature sheet, **except that it is the issue itself**: no separate stamp is sold, so the number of stamps equals the print quantity of the souvenir sheet (e.g. *Mother Teresa*).

(iii) Stamp Sheetlet

A smaller version of a full issue sheet, generally containing **16 to 20** stamps, with complementary illustrations and inscriptions like a miniature sheet. Its aim is to give collectors a sheet of manageable size; it is not brought out on every occasion. Its price is invariably the **sum of the face value** of the stamps it contains.

(iv) Stamp Booklet

A convenient-sized booklet to help a customer who visits post offices frequently to buy stamps; it therefore relates to **definitive stamps**. A booklet may hold a strip of, say, **20 stamps** or fewer, tucked inside the inner fold by gumming the selvedge. The outer cover may carry illustrations and inscriptions. It may be priced at the face value of the stamps it contains.

9. Special Cover

An event that is not important enough nationally to warrant a commemorative/special stamp — or which cannot be fitted into the annual stamp programme — may be marked by a **Special Cover** cancelled with a special cancellation at a chosen post office. Special covers can also be issued at the instance of private parties on payment of the prescribed charges. Such covers must bear postage stamps of any kind at least equal to the **minimum inland letter mail rate**. **Heads of Circles** are competent to sanction special covers for any event/institution/inaugural flight within their jurisdiction.

10. First Flight Cover

A cover carried on the **inaugural mail flight** between two points by an airline, bearing the marks of both places, is called a First Flight Cover.

11. Pictorial Cancellation

A **permanent, regular date cancellation** provided at a post office located at a place of tourist attraction; it normally features the place's major attraction. The **Head of Circle** approves it. It is advisable to provide a pictorial cancellation at places of special interest.

12. Perforation

A series of holes punched along the boundaries of stamps in a sheet to make it easy to **separate the stamps** from one another.

13. Albums

Albums are prepared from time to time by the Philately Division of the Directorate and by the philatelic bureaux for **presentation** and **stamp-release functions**. One common type is prepared at the release of a new special/commemorative stamp or special cover.

14. Blow-Up

A **hand-painted or digital enlargement** of a postage stamp, generally unveiled at a release function as a token of release. It is also available for purchase in limited quantities, made only on demand.

15. Collector's Packs

A Collector's Pack contains a set of **all the commemorative/special stamps** issued by the Department during the year. It is put on sale at philatelic bureaux and can be made available at counters and authorised offices on request. Made in limited quantity.

16. Thematic Packs

From time to time the Department issues sets of two or more stamps on particular **themes**. Small packs containing these stamps are placed on sale at bureaux so that all the stamps on a theme are available together; they can also be supplied through counters/authorised offices on request.

17. List / Catalogue of India Postage Stamps

The list carries information on definitive as well as special/commemorative stamps, including service stamps. A **List/Catalogue of India postage stamps issued since 1947** is sold at philatelic bureaux at a price fixed by the Department.

18. Posters / Fliers

The Department periodically issues publicity leaflets called **fliers**, distributed free to philatelists/collectors to give advance publicity to proposed stamps. **Posters** are also issued to publicise forthcoming stamps and to popularise stamp collecting. These are to be displayed prominently in bureaux/counters and important post offices as soon as received.

19. Newsletter

A **newsletter** is published periodically by the Postal Department carrying information about stamps, forthcoming commemorative/special stamps, special covers, cancellations and exhibitions. It is supplied free, on request, to individuals, philatelic clubs/societies, stamp dealers and collectors in India and abroad.

20. Exhibits

An **exhibit** is an album sheet of standard size **23 × 29 cm** in white or off-white, without any margin. All exhibits must be mounted on standard loose-leaf quadrille album pages and enclosed in transparent protective covers of sufficient firmness. Exhibits mounted on non-standard pages do not meet the model regulations for state/circle-level philatelic exhibitions and will not be displayed there.

21. Meghdoot Postcard

The **Meghdoot Post Card** is a premium variant of the ordinary post card, introduced by the Business Development Directorate w.e.f. **1 September 2002**. The address side carries multi-colour advertisements of clients' products/services at a fixed rate; the client also specifies the territory of circulation. In addition to client-designated territories, limited numbers are available for sale from **seven** selected philatelic bureaux authorised for new postal stationery.

22. Philatelic Bureau

A **Philatelic Bureau** is a branch of a Head or Sub Post Office specifically set up to deal with the receipt and sale of all philatelic items — special/commemorative stamps, FDCs, special covers, new definitive issues and new stationery. It provides **special cancellations** on FDCs, special covers, or covers presented for the purpose. It keeps up-to-date records of all issues, maintains **Philatelic Deposit Accounts** and handles **mail orders**.

23. Philatelic Counter

A **Philatelic Counter** is a counter for the sale of philatelic items, forming part of a post office specially selected for the purpose; one functions in **each Head Post Office**. Counters do **not** provide special cancellation on FDCs/special covers — only a standard "**First Day of Issue**" cancellation, which is the same for all issues. They offer registration for opening a Philatelic Deposit Account, with the material supplied by the parent bureau.

24. Authorised Office

An **Authorised Office** is a post office that sells philatelic items but provides **no special cancellation**. In addition to bureaux and counters, such offices are specially authorised by the Heads of Circles to sell philatelic items.

25. National Philatelic Museum

Each postage stamp is a carefully designed piece of miniature art that speaks about the subject depicted on it. The **National Philatelic Museum, New Delhi**, located in **Dak Bhavan, Sansad Marg**, showcases the Indian panorama through its stamps and houses all Indian stamps issued since Independence. Its main display is the **chronological series** of all

commemorative and special stamps. Blow-ups and children's stamp-design paintings add colour; exhibits by accomplished philatelists are displayed from time to time; and the design and printing process is shown in serialised exhibits. The museum also presents India's postal history and philatelic heritage, and its sale counter offers the latest stamps, FDCs and other material.

25-A. My Stamp (Personalised / Customised Stamps) — current product

My Stamp is India Post's brand for a **personalised sheet of postage stamps**. A customer, corporate, institution or organisation can have a **thumbnail photograph** (of a person, family, artwork, monument, tourist place, wildlife, logo, etc.) printed alongside a selected thematic commemorative stamp. Unlike a commemorative stamp (which needs a two-year process through the Philatelic Advisory Committee), a My Stamp takes only a few minutes to process at the counter on submission of the required photograph, ID and fee.

- **Launched:** at the World Philatelic Exhibition **INDIPEX-2011** (New Delhi), later extended to all Postal Circles.
- **Availability:** selected philatelic bureaux/counters, important post offices, philatelic museums and post offices at tourist places.
- **Sheet composition:** one My Stamp sheet contains **12 stamps**, each of **Rs. 5** face value; the stamp is valid for domestic postage.
- **Price: Rs. 300 per sheet** (customised), with quantity discounts (about 10% for 2–100 sheets and 20% on additional sheets over 100).

UPDATE — ADDED, VERIFIED AS ON 21 JULY 2025

My Stamp is not part of the original handbook text. It is added here as a current, examinable India Post philatelic product. Face value (Rs. 5), sheet composition (12 stamps) and price (Rs. 300/sheet) are as published on the India Post Philately portal (app.indiapost.gov.in/philately). Confirm the current price/discount from the portal, as these are revised from time to time.

Chapter II — Philatelic Bureaux and Counters

26. Establishment of a Philatelic Bureau

Philatelic bureaux are established by the **Heads of Circles** on orders issued by the Directorate. The pre-requisites are the **expected sale** of philatelic items (commemorative/special stamps, FDCs, information sheets, collector packs, special packs, publications, covers, etc.) and the **existence of philatelic societies/clubs** at the place. Before proposing a bureau, the Head of Circle must give the sale figures of philatelic items for the preceding **six months** and the number of clubs/societies at the station. Normally, a new bureau is not opened unless a philatelic **counter** has already been working satisfactorily there.

27. Opening a Philatelic Counter

Counters function at all Head Post Offices. The **Head of Circle** may open a counter at any Sub Post Office in the jurisdiction after being personally satisfied of the need. Guidelines for examining proposals:

1. The place should be a very important **tourist centre**.
2. There should be popular demand from the public/philatelists.
3. There should be a considerable number of philatelic clubs/societies.
4. The proposed office should be accessible by air/train, etc.
5. The office should be an important sub post office.
6. The average monthly sale from the authorised office proposed to be converted should not be less than **Rs. 10,000/-**.

28. Distinction between a Bureau and a Counter

Neither a bureau nor a counter is an independent office — both are part of a post office. **Bureaux** are preferably in Head Post Offices at Circle HQs, district towns and (where necessary) Sub Post Offices. Where a bureau is not justified, a **counter** may be opened in a departmental sub post office.

Bureaux carry out **all** philatelic functions and supply items to dependent counters and to specially authorised post offices. **Counters** do philatelic work in a restricted way: they cannot issue special cancellations, cannot accept mail orders, but may provide the "**First Day of Issue**" cancellation on FDCs (using a permanent canceller with changeable dates), and may register Philatelic Deposit Accounts (material supplied by the parent bureau). **Authorised offices** sell only commemorative/special stamps, blank FDCs and information sheets.

29. Functions of Philatelic Bureaux

Bureaux are under the technical and administrative control of the **Postmaster**. Counters are administratively under their own postmasters but **technically** under the bureau on which they depend for supplies.

29.1 Major functions — to receive and sell:

- Commemorative and special postage stamps and philatelic ancillaries.
- Definitive postage stamps on their first day of issue.
- First Day Covers and Special Covers.
- Information sheets.
- New postal stationery with advertisement.
- Other items such as mini/souvenir sheets, collector's packs, etc.
- Philatelic products such as books, gifts and other merchandise.

NOTE — STATIONERY WITH ADVERTISEMENT

Postal stationery with advertisement is sold only through the philatelic bureaux at **Bangalore, Chennai, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai and Sansad Marg (New Delhi)**, for **one month** from the date of release or till stock lasts, whichever is earlier.

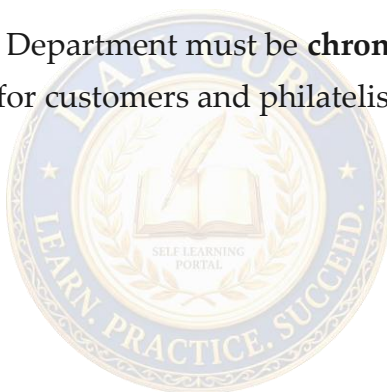
29.2 In addition, the bureau also:

1. Provides special cancellations on the first day of issue.
2. Supplies philatelic stamps and ancillaries to all counters in its technical jurisdiction before the day of release.
3. Supplies material to PDA holders registered at counters.
4. Operates an imprest sanctioned by the Head of Circle to obtain stamps from the treasury for counter sale.
5. Maintains Philatelic Deposit Accounts.
6. Executes mail orders of stamps, FDCs, brochures, etc.
7. Complies with bulk sale of mint stamps.
8. Assists philatelists, dealers, collectors and the public with information on the latest issues.
9. Maintains a philatelic library.
10. Opens extension counters at stamp-release functions organised by the Heads of Circles and others.

11. Assists the Heads of Circles, Regional Directors and Superintendents in organising exhibitions, seminars, workshops, etc.
12. Adopts measures for the sale of philatelic material under the Head of Circle's instructions.
13. Submits periodical statements on the sale of commemorative/special stamps and other material and the number of PD Accounts, plus any other philatelic work entrusted.
14. Maintains a register of philatelic clubs/societies and reputed philatelists of the town.
15. Keeps the catalogue of stamps updated, entering each stamp (commemorative/definitive) as issued.
16. Uses the **Software for Philatelic Inventory Management** — bureaux/HO treasuries are progressively networked, with connectivity to CSDs / Circle Offices / Philately Division for MIS. The software updates and monitors indents, invoice forecasts, stock in hand, sales and revenue.

30. Display of Stamps in the Philatelic Bureau

Stamps and FDCs issued by the Department must be **chronologically arranged and kept in an album** as reference material for customers and philatelists.



Chapter III — Stamps

31. Advance Notification of a Stamp Issue

The issue of a stamp is notified by a **circular** issued by the Directorate well in advance of the release date to all Heads of Circles / Regional PMsG and the bureaux. It carries full information including technical data; photo-prints of the stamp(s), when available, are sent for advance publicity. The Head of Circle ensures all bureaux, counters and authorised offices know the date of issue, subject and denomination. On receipt, the **Postmaster** must give maximum publicity and display the circular on the notice board; a press note is sent to the DPIO for media publicity.

32. Embargo on Premature Sale

A stamp must **never be sold before the notified date of issue**. If the fixed date is a Sunday/postal holiday, the bureaux in New Delhi and at the place of issue open for sale on that date, while other bureaux/counters sell and provide the actual-date cancellation on the **next working day**. If the issue is postponed/advanced for technical/administrative reasons, the Directorate informs all Heads of Circles, who inform all bureaux/counters. It is the **personal responsibility of the Postmaster** to convey any change promptly and ensure the stamp is not issued on the previously notified date.

33. Receipt and Custody of Stamp Packets

Commemorative/special stamps are sent in **secured packets** bearing the date of issue from the authorised stamp depot to all bureaux and selected counters. The number received is fixed by the Directorate; depending on the print quantity a **quota** is fixed for each bureau/counter (Annex I). On receipt, the Postmaster verifies the authorised quota. Each packet has a "**Not to be sold before [date]**" label. The Postmaster has the packet opened in his presence, counts the sheets to detect any discrepancy, and ensures safe custody. Stamps required by attached counters/authorised offices are dispatched well in advance of release per the Head of Circle's quota, with a warning that they must not be sold before the date of issue.

34. Register of Commemorative Stamp Balances

The **treasurer** of the HO/SO selling commemorative stamps maintains the register in the prescribed proforma (as for postal stamps and stationery), listing each stamp vertically with the balance against it and the total at the foot. Stamps are entered chronologically on receipt at **face value**; their value forms part of the office cash balance and is treated like other stamps

and stationery. Dispatches to dependent counters/authorised offices (under Remittance Advice or S.O. slips) are entered by the treasurer.

This register is maintained **in addition to** the stamp register for definitive/non-postage stamps. Daily totals are transferred to the HO Summary. When stamps are supplied to the attached bureau/counter for sale, the treasurer recoups cash against the stamp imprest given to the incharge. The register ensures correct accounting and shows the stock position of commemorative/special stamps on any date. A **register of commemorative/special stamps released** (Annex II) is kept in the bureau; keeping it updated is the personal responsibility of the incharge.

NOTE — INVENTORY SOFTWARE

The **Software for Philatelic Inventory Management** (covering definitives, postal stationery and commemorative/special stamps) is being introduced department-wide in a phased manner and its use is **mandatory**. It updates stock and sales, indicates revenue and aids forecasting and indenting.

35. Sale of Commemorative / Special Stamps

Commemorative/special stamps must **not** be sold through stamp vendors or licensed agents — only through bureaux/counters and authorised offices. The incharge obtains supply from the authorised stamp depot. Before sale on release day, adequate stock is retained to meet **PD Account** requirements. On release day, extra counters may be needed in big offices, with staff drawn from other branches. At the close of each day the incharge transfers sale proceeds to the treasurer. The bureau must never hold cash or stamps (or both) in excess of its **imprest**.

A bureau/counter sells stamps of each issue for **6 months** from the month of issue or till supply lasts, whichever is earlier. At the end of 6 months, stamps on **personalities, events and institutions** are transferred to the Philatelic Bureau of the GPO/HO at the Circle HQ to which the stamp relates (e.g. a stamp on a Tamil Nadu personality → Anna Road HO, Chennai). The list of identified offices is at Annex III.

35.1 Greater visibility after 6 months

To improve availability, commemorative stamps unsold after 6 months are released for sale **alongside definitive stamps** at the parent office's stamp-vending counter and remitted to other post offices that do not sell philatelic stamps, under the usual remittance procedure. Multicoloured stamps of higher denominations, after 6 months at the bureau, are issued for sale at **Speed Post / Parcel / Registration** counters.

35.2 Meeting additional demand

If, before issue, a proponent/interested party wishes to buy the stamp and ancillaries, the Head of Circle/Regional PMG ascertains the requirement and informs the Directorate at least **one month** in advance if the Circle quota cannot meet it; payment is taken in advance, credited under **Unclassified Receipts**, and intimation given to the Philately Branch. For additional demand after issue, the bureau informs the Head of Circle/Regional PMG, who explores meeting it at inter-circle level; Central Base Post Offices take it up through APS with the Chief PMG, New Delhi/Kolkata as the case may be.

35.3 PD Account stock first

Before stamps are put on sale, or any diversion is made, adequate stock must be retained to meet PD Account requirements.



Chapter IV — First Day Covers & Information Sheets

36. Supply of First Day Covers

With every new commemorative/special stamp, a **First Day Cover (FDC)** is issued. FDCs are printed and supplied by the Postal Directorate through the Philatelic Bureau, **Sansad Marg HPO, New Delhi**, to all bureaux. They come in two sizes — **13 × 20 cm** and **11 × 20 cm**. The quota per bureau is fixed by the Directorate and reviewed periodically by sales. FDCs are normally **not** supplied to authorised offices, which cannot give the First-Day cancellation. They are supplied in advance of the issue date. A bureau may indent **additional** quantities if extra demand is anticipated, provided the demand reaches the Directorate at least **one month** before release.

On receipt, the incharge counts the FDCs against the invoice, enters the quantity in the special stock register, and supplies FDCs to all counters before the release date as per the Head of Circle's quota.

37. Sale of First Day Covers

FDCs (blank or stamped) **cannot be sold before** the stamp's issue date. FDCs with the newly issued stamp(s) affixed and cancelled with the special first-day cancellation can be sold on the release date. The **First Day of Issue cancellation** on FDCs bearing the concerned commemorative stamp(s) continues for **four weeks** from the actual date of issue. As FDCs are philatelic items, a buyer often keeps them without posting.

If a collector wishes to post an FDC to a friend, it must be presented at the philatelic counter for transmission with the first-day cancellation. FDCs should **not** be dropped in letter boxes, as they may then get the collecting office's date stamp and lose philatelic value. Blank FDCs may be used as ordinary envelopes (without the first-day cancellation) and posted in letter boxes.

Before FDCs go on sale on the issue day, and before supply to other offices, the incharge keeps aside enough FDCs for PD Account holders. Sale proceeds of FDCs are credited under **Unclassified Receipts**; the incharge periodically tallies the account with the stock register.

38. Disposal of First Day Covers

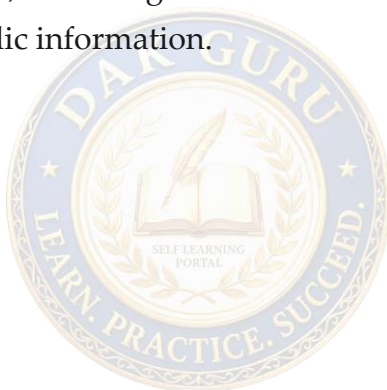
Blank FDCs unsold after **six months** from the month of issue are obliterated on the motif (if printed) with a thick cross "X" and superscribed "**On Postal Service**" (by rubber stamp), for purely **inter-departmental use**. Under no circumstances are such covers to be sent to the public. However, FDCs (after 6 months) relating to **personalities** are transferred to the CPO/HO of the Circle HQ to which the personality relates.

39. Information Sheets

Information sheets/brochures are printed and supplied by the Directorate to all bureaux through Sansad Marg HO, New Delhi, per the fixed quota, well before the stamp's issue date. On receipt they are checked and entered in the stock register like FDCs. They **cannot be sold before** the stamp is issued. Bureaux should indent realistically to keep unsold quantities minimal. On request, a special cancellation may be provided on information sheets kept as collectibles.

40. Disposal of Unsold Information Sheets

Information sheets unsold after **6 months** from the stamp's issue date may be disposed of so as to promote philately — e.g. free distribution among students, at exhibitions, or to philatelic clubs/societies — and **written off** from the stock register at the end of 6 months. Those on **personalities** are transferred to the GPO/HO of the relevant Circle HQ. The incharge periodically ensures sale proceeds of brochures are credited to the office account and checks unsold stock against the register, initialling the entries. A copy of the brochure is displayed on the HO notice board for public information.



Chapter V — Procedure for Supply to Philatelists and Collectors

41. Scope of Supply

A bureau supplies only the **current India special postage stamps** as newly issued, plus FDCs and special covers issued on any event/occasion per earlier notifications. Orders must be **accompanied by remittances** (money order or postal order) and the full delivery address; the remittance should include an extra amount for postage and, if desired, insurance fee.

Orders are executed per the applicant's instructions as long as stamps are available. When a new/revised item of postal stationery (postcards, inland letter cards, aerogrammes, embossed/registration envelopes) is released, collectors may want it cancelled with the bureau's date stamp on the **date of issue** to show it was procured that day; this may be done even if unaddressed, and the item handed over — with the caution that such cancelled stationery will **not** be accepted for transmission if posted elsewhere or on another date. Advance orders for such cancelled stationery are booked on the same terms as new stamps and FDCs.

42. Selection of Stamps for Supply

Supplies are made in **sheets, blocks or loose labels** as desired. Mint sheets must be free of pencil writing on the back, not creased or folded, with **well-centred perforations**. When breaking a sheet for small orders, fold it along the breaking line first so the perforations are not damaged. Stamps with gum stains or marks are of no use to collectors and must not be sent.

43. Packing

While packing, two gummed sides must never touch (stamps would stick and be spoilt). Fold a full sheet in half with the printed sides facing each other; place a blank transparent sheet between sheets. All stamps are sent protected between **two cardboards**. Small orders may go in cloth-bound covers or transparent polythene envelopes inside an outer paper cover. Large parcels, besides cardboard protection, are first wrapped in packing paper so the cardboard edges do not cut through and damage the stamps.

44. Mail Orders

When a series of stamps is issued, **mail-order forms** are printed by the Department and distributed free to collectors to facilitate advance booking.

44.1 – 44.2 Receipt of advance payments

For advance cash received for supply of FDCs and new stamps: all such cash is taken as payment by the Postmaster, who grants a receipt in form **ACG-67** and accounts for it under "**Unclassified Receipts**", maintaining these particulars in a separate register:

1. Date of receipt.
2. Name and address of the philatelist.
3. Details of FDCs, brochures and stamps ordered.
4. Value of the items plus postage for dispatch.
5. Total amount received.
6. Number of the ACG-67 receipt.
7. Initials of the Treasurer for the amount in column 5.
8. Date and manner of final adjustment (if sent by post — number/date of the registered letter; if delivered at counter — dated signature of the recipient).

44.3 Adjustment on issue day

The bureau incharge fills columns 1–6. On the day the stamps are issued, the Postmaster charges the advance under "**Unclassified Payments**", supported by a covering sanction (with an extract of the register) issued by the Divisional Superintendent/Postmaster (Group 'B' and above).

45. Delivery of Orders

For counter delivery, the incharge prepares separate covers for each philatelist and hands them over after obtaining dated initials in column 8, recording on the back of the ACG-67 receipt that supplies were made in person. For orders sent by post, the incharge dispatches by **registered post**, paste the receipt against the order in the register. Undelivered counter packets are kept separately for later delivery.

46. Balance / Shortfall

Any amount left after meeting the order cost is returned in **current postage stamps**; if the remittance falls short, the order is reduced by the corresponding value.

47. Protective Packing

While dispatching against orders, material is properly packed with **cellophane envelopes and cardboards** so the envelopes do not give way in transit; bubble packing may be used where fit.

48. Online PDAs

The handbook envisaged that opening and operating Philatelic Deposit Accounts online would be enabled through the **e-Post Office**, with operational instructions to be notified.

UPDATE — ONLINE PHILATELY NOW LIVE

This has been realised. India Post now offers online purchase of philatelic items and online operation of Philatelic Deposit Accounts through its philately portal / ePost Office. Confirm the exact current portal and process from India Post (indiapost.gov.in) as the interface is periodically upgraded.



Chapter VI – Cancellation

49. Types of Cancellation

Cancellations provided by philatelic bureaux are of the following types:

1. Special First Day Cancellation.
2. Special Place Cancellation.
3. Philatelic Exhibition Cancellation.
4. Pictorial Cancellation.
5. Special cancellation to commemorate an event, institution or inaugural flight.

50. Special First Day Cancellation

Special first-day cancellations (and first-day-issue cancellation) are provided on FDCs, private covers and album pages bearing the commemorative stamps, at the bureaux, for **six months** from the day of issue. Counters do not give the special first-day cancellation; they use a standard cancellation reading "**First Day of Issue**" with the changeable date stamp of the office of issue on the issue date.

51. Custody and Use of Date Stamps

Bureaux/counters are supplied with date stamps inscribed "**Philatelic Bureau**" or "**Philatelic Counter**" and a hand stamp reading "**First Day of Issue**". These must be kept in the **personal custody** of the Postmaster / Asstt. Postmaster / Supervisor / Incharge, who is responsible for any misuse. The types meant for this stamp must not be used for other office stamps.

51.1 Use of date stamps

The ordinary date stamp ("Philatelic Bureau"/"Philatelic Counter") is used to cancel postal stationery bearing advertisements. The "**First Day of Issue**" stamp is used whenever new stationery with a new design is issued; at counters it is also used whenever special/commemorative stamps are issued (since special cancellation cachets are not supplied to counters).

51.2 Supply of the common cachet design

A **common design** of the cancellation cachet for the particular special/commemorative stamp(s) is sent to all Heads of Circles by the Philately Branch of the Directorate, well in advance. The Head of Circle gets the cachet manufactured and supplied to all bureaux to reach them before the issue date. The cachet must conform to the specification in Rule 6. On receipt and after checking, it is kept in the personal custody of the Postmaster and used **only**

on the designated dates. Heads of Circles must watch their e-mail so cachets are prepared in time and any change of dates is caught.

51.3 Correct date and ink

Cachets must bear the **correct date, month and year** before use; the clerk and supervisor check this personally and initial the **Book of Post Marks** against the impression taken. Use of any ink other than **black** is prohibited.

52. Return of Special Cancellation Cachet

The First-Day-Issue cancellation on FDCs continues for **six months** from the actual day of issue. Special covers also remain on sale, with special cancellation, at the nominated offices for **six months** from issue. Orders for FDCs and special covers placed before issue but received by post after issue are still **honoured**. The bureau keeps the cachet in the Postmaster's personal custody after the issue date (of the stamp) or the date of the special cover, to execute mail orders and provide cancellations. The cachet must be **returned** to the **Supdt., Postal Forms and Seals, Aligarh** — **six months** after the release of the stamp, or **one month** in the case of a special cover — after executing mail orders and supplying deposit-account holders. Any change in disposal orders will be notified.

53. Special Place Cancellations

Special cancellations are sometimes provided at places (other than bureaux/counters) that have special significance to the stamp. Information is issued by circular to official agencies and by newsletter/postal notice for collectors. Places of special significance are described in the stamp's brochure. Post offices at such places provide their own cancellation on demand; a **pictorial cancellation** is provided where possible. Articles need not be sent to bureaux/counters unless asked for, if a pictorial cancellation is available at the place of posting.

54. Philatelic Exhibition Cancellations

These are approved by the **Heads of Circles** for exhibitions organised by philatelic clubs/societies/organisations, and also for exhibitions by non-philatelic bodies (educational institutions, Rotary, Lions, etc.). Circle- and district-level exhibitions are held by the Department; **national and international** exhibitions are organised by the Directorate, New Delhi. Heads of Circles may permit cancellations **in advance** of a departmental exhibition for publicity, at selected offices. The **Postmaster General** may approve special cancellations for exhibitions (departmental or not) in consultation with the Head of Circle.

55. Pictorial Cancellations

Pictorial cancellations are provided at post offices located at places of major **historical importance or tourist attraction**, introduced on a specific date and publicised through circulars/notices and the newsletter. They **replace the ordinary round date stamp** of that office and continue as a regular measure until discontinued by the Head of Circle. The **Postmaster General** approves them in consultation with the Head of Circle.

56. Special Cancellation — Terms and Conditions

Heads of Circles are competent to sanction special cancellation and covers commemorating any event/institution/inaugural flight in their jurisdiction, subject to:

A. Approval considerations: the subject/occasion is of considerable State-level importance; it will boost local philatelic interest; it is non-controversial with no communal/political overtones; and the proponents are reputable and credible (not indulging in activities embarrassing to the Government of India).

B. Proponent to provide: the proposed date of issue; the proposed design; and the name(s) of the post office(s)/venue from where the cancellation is to be provided.

C. Legend: the design's legend is **bilingual (Hindi first, then English)**, indicating the date and only the event/occasion. It incorporates the **name and PIN** of the post office (or, for a separate venue, the PIN of the office in whose delivery jurisdiction the venue lies). The design must be a **line drawing** for neat impressions.

D. Nature: the design must be **secular** and free of any nuance that could embarrass the Government.

E. Fees: the proponent pays the prescribed fees **in advance**.

F. Manufacture: the cachet is made by the concerned **Circle Office** as per the design approved by the Head of Circle.

56.1 The Department may reject any application, or disallow/modify any design or inscription, **without assigning a reason**.

56.2 All cancellations must be neat and clean, with properly engraved cachets; bureaux may use a treadle machine or other approved device for clear impressions.

56.3 For a new (national/international) airline flight, a request may be received to carry addressed covers on the inaugural flight. A special cancellation is provided at the **point of origin**; covers are offered to the bureau on the eve of the flight, cancelled, closed in a **blue air-mail bag** and handed to the airline under receipt. Destination post-marks can also be

provided if requested; this can be arranged abroad if the request comes sufficiently in advance.

57. Design of Cancellation

Designs of first-day and special cancellations are selected by the Department. They may be **pictorial or non-pictorial** but must contain the theme/subject of the occasion. Special-place cancellations share the theme of the first-day cancellation but carry the name of the particular (non-bureau) post office.

57.1 For exhibition cancellations, the design may be pictorial or non-pictorial, preferably with a **slogan** promoting philately, indicating the exhibition's name, the date(s) and the post office. Different cancellations are usually provided for each day (inaugural day, post-office day, philatelists' day, award day, etc.). A pictorial design must be a **simple line drawing** for clear impressions.

57.2 For pictorial cancellations at places of historical/tourist importance, the design must relate to that significance, be a simple line drawing, and be **bilingual in Hindi and English** (regional language not used). **Hindi appears on top, English below**; numerals (date, year) are in **Arabic numerals** only.

58. Manufacture of Cancellation Cachet

Cachets for first-day and special-place cancellations are supplied by the Head of Circle to the bureaux/offices concerned. The Directorate circulates the common design (with the release date) to all Heads of Circles, who get the cachets made and supplied to all bureaux in their jurisdiction; exhibition cachets are likewise supplied by the concerned Head of Circle. For **exhibition** cancellations (fixed dates), the Head of Circle arranges local manufacture after the design is approved. For **pictorial** cancellations at places of historical/tourist importance, the Head of Circle takes it up with the **Supdt., Postal Forms and Seals, Aligarh**, supplying the design well in advance; as this replaces the date stamp, it must allow insertion of types for **date, month and year**.

59. Guidelines for Providing Special Cancellation

Heads of Circles may approve special cancellation in all cases **except those concerning India's diplomatic relations**, which remain with the Directorate, on realisation of the prescribed fees. All proposals for exhibition and pictorial cancellations are scrutinised and **personally approved** by the Head of Circle. Proposals should ordinarily be entertained if received at least **8 weeks** in advance. The design must suit the theme, spellings must be correct, and it must be **bilingual (Hindi and English)**. A copy of the approval letter with the design is sent to the Philately Branch for information and newsletter publicity. The Head of

Circle also ensures countrywide publicity at least **15 days** in advance for the benefit of philatelists, and may send a press note to the Press Information Bureau.

60. Charges for Special Cancellation

Once approved, the proponent pays:

- **Working days:** Rs. 1,500/- per day per post office; Rs. 3,000/- if provided at the proponent's premises.
- **Sundays / postal holidays:** Rs. 3,000/- per day per post office; Rs. 6,000/- per day at the proponent's premises.

The cancellation/cover is provided during the post office's **normal working hours**. The Head of Circle may allow a **50% concession** for a special cancellation during a District, State, Circle or National philatelic exhibition **not organised by the Department**.

NOTE — FEES SUBJECT TO REVISION

These fee figures are as stated in the handbook. Charges are revised by Directorate circular from time to time — confirm the current rates before quoting them as operative.

61. Formal Release Function of a Special Cover

61.1 The Department does not normally organise a formal function for the release of Special Covers. A proponent may request the Head of Circle for permission, sufficiently in advance, with a **minute-to-minute programme, dais plan and draft invitation card**, so that protocol and uniformity are maintained.

61.2 Any formal release of a Special Cover by a central/state government dignitary should have an appropriate departmental representative (usually the Head of Circle/Regional PMG). Exceptions are made only when the **President, Vice-President, Prime Minister, Speaker (Lok Sabha) or a Governor/Lt. Governor** consents to release the cover — then the MOC/MOS(C) normally presents the first Album for release, so the MOC/MOS(C) must deliver the speech and introduce the cover before its release. Whoever the invited dignitary, invitation letters must issue from the **proponent** to the MOC/MOS(C) and Secretary (DoP), or to the CPMG/PMG for Circle/Region functions, to ascertain their convenience.

61.3 The level of departmental representation depends on the level/status of the VIP receiving the first Album.

61.4 The **organiser** is responsible for all arrangements — invitation cards, site preparation, security, liaison with press/TV, etc.

61.5 If necessary, the proponent arranges (at own cost) distribution of special covers to VIPs and the material used in the presentation Albums.

61.6 No formal release function may be held **without specific prior approval** of the Department; without such approval, the Department takes no responsibility for extending its usual support.



Chapter VII — Deposit Account System

62. Domestic Philatelic Deposit Account (PDA)

A **domestic philatelic deposit account** system was introduced w.e.f. **1 August 1965** at all philatelic bureaux in India. Account holders are supplied with commemorative/special stamps, FDCs, information sheets and new postal stationery soon after issue. **Postal stationery with advertisement** is supplied through PDAs only at the selected bureaux — **Bangalore, Chennai, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai and Sansad Marg (New Delhi)**. A holder can also obtain items issued by other bureaux/offices by placing demands with the bureau where the account stands; that bureau consolidates the demands and indents on the issuing office, treating the dispatch as a remittance to another HO.

Counters at all Head Post Offices offer **registration** to open a PDA, with material supplied by the parent bureau; customers may choose to collect from the counter of registration.

62.1 The handbook envisaged online opening/operation of PDAs through the **Virtual Post Office**, with instructions to be notified.

UPDATE — ONLINE PDA NOW LIVE

Online PDA operation and online sale of philatelic items are now available through India Post's philately portal / ePost Office. Verify the current portal and procedure from indiapost.gov.in.

63. Conditions of Service

A PDA may be opened with a **minimum deposit of Rs. 200/-** (cash, MO, or cheque/draft encashable in India). The holder indicates the types and quantities of items desired with each new issue, and notifies address changes in time. Indicated items are dispatched **automatically** without further order. Dispatches are made **once a month, in the first week**, covering all issues of the previous month; if there is no issue, no dispatch is made. A holder wanting dispatch immediately after every release is debited full postage and registration fee.

64. Mode of Dispatch and Charges

Items are dispatched **free "On Postal Service" by registered post** unless the customer wants insured post (then the insurance fee is debited). No separate registration/insurance/postage charge is levied unless the customer specifically desires otherwise.

64.1 A holder may also **collect** items at the bureau counter after each issue — but **not** on the issue date; on subsequent dates only.

64.2 With each dispatch a **statement of account** is sent, showing the value supplied and the balance. The customer replenishes the deposit when the balance is too low to cover a single order, by **not less than Rs. 200/-**. The account becomes **inoperative** when the balance is less than a single order's value, and is revived only on a fresh Rs. 200/- deposit. If no fresh deposit is made within **three months** of the account becoming inoperative, the balance (less commission) is remitted by money order and the account **finally closed**. An account may also be closed on the depositor's request.

65. How to Open a PDA

Send an application in the prescribed proforma (Annex IV) to the philatelic bureau. A list of bureaux is at Annex V.

66. Procedure at the Bureau

The bureau maintains an **order register** and a **ledger** (Annex VI-A / VI-B) and prepares a monthly statement of supplies to PDA holders.

66.1 On receipt of the application, particulars are noted chronologically in the Order Register; required particulars are filled and signed by the officer-in-charge, and the application with the deposit is sent to the Treasurer for credit under **Unclassified Receipts**.

66.2 After credit is intimated, an account is opened in the **ledger**; particulars are noted carefully and the supervisor initials the entries and the dispatch instructions. The applicant is told the date of opening and the **account number**; the application is placed in a guard file with the PDA number.

66.3 On each dispatch, ledger entries are made, the balance struck and initialled by the Supervisor, and a **statement of account** (Annex VII) prepared and sent with the dispatch, tallying with the ledger.

66.4 A **monthly statement** of supplies under the Deposit Account is prepared; the amount is charged under "**Unclassified Payment**", supported by a covering sanction for the consolidated amount issued by the Divisional Superintendent/Postmaster (Group 'B' and above). One copy of the statement with the sanction memo is sent to the Postmaster for onward dispatch to the **Director of Accounts (Postal)** with the monthly cash account.

66.5 Items are packed with cellophane envelopes and cardboard for protection.

67. Concessions to Clubs and Societies

Philatelic clubs/associations are encouraged to open deposit accounts; items ordered by them are dispatched **free On Postal Service by registered post** provided the minimum value of an

order at a time is **Rs. 500/-** or above. Individual members collect their items from such clubs/associations.

68. Stamps of U.N. and Other Countries

Stamps of other countries and the U.N. are sometimes sold in India through bureaux. Being non-Indian issues, they fall **outside the PDA system** and must be bought in the normal course. They are sold only through selected bureaux — **Bangalore, Chennai, Kolkata, Mumbai and Sansad Marg (New Delhi)** — and are **not** supplied to counters.

69. Deposit Account Service for Foreign Collectors

This service is available only at **Philatelic Bureau, Mumbai**. No other bureau entertains foreign applications; any received are forwarded to the **Director, Philatelic Bureau, Mumbai GPO – 400001**, with intimation to the applicant.

70. Items Supplied (Foreign)

Foreign collectors may place standing orders (printed on the application form) for new commemorative/special Indian stamps, FDCs, new stationery and brochures, supplied automatically by Philatelic Bureau, Mumbai; they may also order the annual **Collectors' Packs**.

71. Opening and Operation (Foreign)

A foreign account is opened with a minimum deposit equivalent to **Rs. 5,000/-** by cheque/bank draft encashable in India. If the amount realised in rupees falls below Rs. 5,000/- due to exchange fluctuation, the account is debited with the difference. The customer indicates the types/quantities desired with each issue; the **minimum order** each time is an amount equivalent to **Rs. 500/-**.

72. Mode of Dispatch (Foreign)

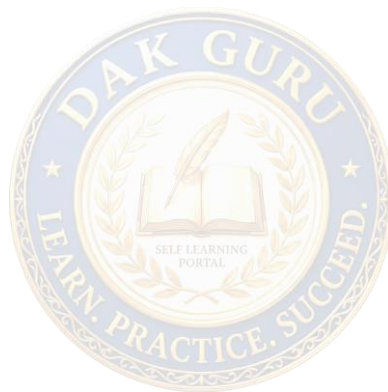
Items are dispatched by **registered post** unless otherwise desired; the actual postage prepaid is debited. A **packing charge of 2%** of the value dispatched on each occasion (minimum **Rs. 10/-**) is also levied.

73. Statement and Replenishment (Foreign)

A statement of account accompanies each dispatch. The customer replenishes the deposit by **not less than the equivalent of Rs. 2,500/-** as it approaches exhaustion. The account becomes inoperative when the balance is less than a single order's value **plus** postage and packing, and is revived only on a fresh minimum deposit.

74. Form for Opening (Foreign)

Send the application (Annex VIII) duly filled to **Philatelic Bureau, Mumbai GPO – 400001 (India)** with the remittance. The form is also available on the Department's website, www.indiapost.gov.in.



Chapter VIII – Miscellaneous

75. Guidelines for Issue of Commemorative / Special Stamps

1. The subject must be a theme of **relevance to the nation**, its policies and issues of concern.
2. Proposals should be taken up well in advance — about **two years** before the proposed issue date — with full details, in the format at Annex IX, to enable examination and recommendation by the **Philatelic Advisory Committee**. The format is also on the India Post website.
3. A stamp on a **living personality** may not be issued.
4. Personalities must be of **national/international importance**; the occasion must be the birth centenary or the **10th/25th/50th/100th death anniversary**. To ensure objective assessment, no stamp is issued sooner than **ten years** after the individual's death — except for deceased Heads of State.
5. Not more than **one** stamp may be issued on the same personality/monument/building/institution/organisation.
6. A stamp on an institution/building/monument may be issued on its **centenary / 125th / 150th** anniversary, etc.; the site must be a **Heritage Preservation site** of national/international importance. Something of regional importance may be marked by a special cover with special cancellation.
7. Only events of very important **national/international** character are considered; regionally significant events are marked by a special cover with special cancellation.
8. Stamps are **not** issued to honour commercial, political or sectarian organisations.
9. Stamps are **not** issued to honour institutions/individuals whose main achievements are confined to **religion**.
10. Stamps are **not** issued to honour schools, colleges, libraries, hospitals, municipalities, cities or similar institutions (given the annual programme's limits and their vast number); if essential, a stamp on the **apex institution** — not individual branches — is advisable.
11. Of the stamps issued each year, those on **personalities** should not normally exceed **25%**; and at least **25%** each year should be on popular themes (flora and fauna, arts and culture, etc.), issued under the series "**Heritage India**" and "**Nature India**".

76. Fictitious Stamps

The **manufacture and use of fictitious postage stamps** for any purpose is prohibited and is a punishable offence. Reproduction of stamps is allowed for **illustration** in philatelic publications or articles wholly about postage stamps in any magazine/newspaper/general

publication, but such reproduction must be only in **black**. To reproduce in **colour** for publicity, prior permission of the **Secretary, Department of Posts** is required.

The Department may levy charges for issuing stamps for publicity, advertising, book covers, etc.; the policy operative at the time should be ascertained. To avoid similarity with genuine stamps, reproduction must be **without perforation** on the edges, and a **cross-bar** placed on one corner obliterating the denomination. A colour reproduction of the actual size **with** perforation may be treated as production of the actual stamp. Stamps used for advertisement, on book covers, CD/DVD sleeves, hoardings or billboards, or for any publicity by anyone other than the Department, are liable to a charge fixed by the Department at the time of approving the use.

UPDATE — VERIFIED AS ON 21 JULY 2025

The penal provision has changed. The offence of fictitious stamps was **Section 263-A of the Indian Penal Code, 1860**. The IPC has been repealed and replaced by the **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023** (Act 45 of 2023), in force from **1 July 2024**. The corresponding provision is now **Section 186 of the BNS, 2023 — "Prohibition of fictitious stamps."**

The substance is unchanged: making, uttering, dealing in, selling, using for postal purposes, or possessing (without lawful excuse) any fictitious stamp — or any die/plate/instrument/material for making one — is punishable with a **fine up to Rs. 200**; such stamp/die/plate/instrument/material may be **seized and forfeited**. (Source: BNS 2023; official IPC–BNS comparative tables.)

Note also that the **Post Office Act, 2023** (in force 18 June 2024), which replaced the Indian Post Office Act, 1898, removed penal provisions from postal law — but the fictitious-stamp offence was always under the penal code, so it survives in BNS Section 186.

77. Coloured Blow-ups of Stamps

The Department brings out blow-ups of stamps on important personalities and events. Selective functions are held to release stamps at places associated with them. The blow-up used at a function is normally **donated to the proponents** as goodwill; where the Department itself arranges the function, the blow-up is neatly **framed and hung** in a nearby post office. Apart from release functions, blow-ups are prepared and supplied to proponents/interested parties on **firm orders with advance payment** at rates fixed by the Department; they may also be supplied (on payment) to Heads of Circles for decorating offices.

78. Release Functions

A release function need not be held for **every** issue — only selectively, per the occasion/proponent. When a proponent organises it, the Head of Circle keeps constant liaison well in advance. When the **Communications Minister** attends, the Head of Circle personally visits the venue beforehand to avoid any inconvenience/embarrassment. The organisers finalise the draft invitation card, dais plan and minute-to-minute programme in advance, a copy going to the Directorate for the Minister's information. When part of a larger function, the stamp release is placed **early** in the programme. Release is normally done by **presenting an album** (stamps + FDC) and **unveiling the blow-up**; the chief guest then displays the album for the media.

Heads of Circles intimate the Directorate well in advance of their requirement of presentation albums, FDCs, souvenir folders, etc., and a blow-up is generally prepared and sent to the Head of Circle in whose jurisdiction the function is held; a representative may collect the material from the Philately Division. The blow-up is **donated to the proponents** at the end. When the Department itself arranges the function, the blow-up is sent to the bureau or the nearest post office. The Head of Circle ensures functions befit the Department's image.

78.1 Guidelines for a Formal Stamp Release Function

1. The Department does not normally organise a formal release function; a proponent (who provides background material for design and brochure) may request permission, well in advance, with a **minute-to-minute programme, dais plan and draft invitation card**.
2. Any formal release should have an appropriate departmental representative. The stamp — the legally valid receipt for postage — is released by the **MOC or MOS(C)**; if neither is available, by the **Secretary (DoP), a Member of the Postal Services Board, or the Chief PMG** concerned. Exceptions are made only when the **President, Vice-President, Prime Minister, Speaker (Lok Sabha) or a Governor/Lt. Governor** consents — then the MOC/MOS(C) requests them to unveil the blow-up and presents the first Album for release, after delivering the speech and introducing the stamp. Invitation letters must issue from the **proponent** to the MOC/MOS(C) and Secretary (DoP). Requests for change of date are generally not entertained, as they reflect poorly on the country's philatelic practices.
3. The proposal for the function must be mooted sufficiently in advance, with the draft programme, invitation cards and dais plan, to ensure the required uniformity, standard and protocol.
4. The level of departmental representation depends on the level/status of the dignitary receiving the first Album.

5. Besides the Presentation Album, the Department contributes: (a) a **blow-up** for display; (b) **deluxe albums** for the principal dignitaries; and (c) **one hundred FDCs** with information brochures for distinguished invitees.
6. Additional albums, FDCs, etc. can be obtained by the organisers **on payment**, the requirement being communicated well in advance to the Department or the concerned Chief PMG, who is kept informed throughout.
7. The Department customarily provides a **special stamp-sale counter** at the venue, on demand.
8. The **organisers** are responsible for all arrangements — invitation cards, site preparation, security, liaison with press/TV, etc.
9. As the stamp is released simultaneously at about **1,200 outlets** nationwide, no change of release date is normally entertained once fixed (brochures and cancellations carry the date; reprinting is an avoidable waste).
10. The organiser must compulsorily invite local **Members of Parliament/State Legislature**, ensure their names appear on the invitation card, and arrange seating per the **Warrant of Precedence**; local members of the **Philatelic Advisory Committee** must also be invited.
11. No formal release function may be held **without prior departmental approval**; without it, the Department takes no responsibility for its usual support.
12. In case of any dispute among proponents, **there is no release function** — sale simply begins across the counter on the scheduled issue date.

78.2 Instructions to departmental officers. Separate instructions exist for departmental functionaries coordinating/organising formal release functions; they supplement the guidelines given to proponents. Heads of Circles/Regional PMsG may refer to **Directorate letter No. 16-143/95-Phil dated 30/10/2002 and 7/11/2002**, or obtain a copy from the Philately Division.

79. Philatelic Assistance in Ceremonial Functions

Postage stamps are sometimes used liberally in local functions — often as albums presented to dais dignitaries to add ceremonial value. Since a postage stamp is the valid legal receipt for postage and stamp collection has philatelic importance, this is a matter of exclusive relevance to the Department. **Unauthorised** liberal use without prior approval must be guarded against; however, there is no objection if organisers, on their own, use an album of stamps **purchased from the Department**.

80. Periodical Report

A **Monthly Report on Philately Promotion and Development** is prescribed for submission to the Postal Directorate (Philately Section). To assess revenue from philatelic material (commemorative/special and definitive stamps, FDCs, new/advertisement stationery, commemorative stationery, etc.), the Circle Office compiles the data from all bureaux/counters and forwards a consolidated statement to the Directorate by the **5th of each month** (Annex X).

(a) Bureaux/counters maintain a register noting sales of: postal stationery with advertisement (designated bureaux only); new/redesigned postal stationery; commemorative stamps of each issue; FDCs and brochures of each issue; collectors' packs; albums; greeting cards; stamp packets; thematic packs; blow-ups; miniature sheets; souvenir sheets; and philatelic items sold during exhibitions.

(b) The register also separately records: fee collected for special cover/cancellation; value of stamps/FDCs/brochures supplied to other counters; amount charged under UCP for supplies under the PD Scheme and delivery of products against advance payment; and the amount of postal stationery and stamps cancelled with special/slogan/exhibition cancellations.

(c) Post offices (other than bureaux) authorised by the Heads of Circles to sell stamps, FDCs and folders maintain a register of such sales; the monthly total (item-wise) is intimated to the Circle Office by the **2nd of the following month** directly.

(d) Authorised offices receiving commemorative/special stamps directly from the Stamp Depot maintain the bureau-prescribed registers (for stamps only) and send the monthly sales statement directly to the Circle Office on the **2nd of each month** (Annex XI).

80.2 Philatelic counters function in each Head Post Office (other than bureaux) and provide registration to open PD Accounts, supplied by the parent bureau. A quarterly statement of PDAs opened is sent to the parent bureau, which consolidates the figures of PDAs at attached counters and sends the consolidated statement (Annex XI) to the Circle Office.

81. New Postal Stationery with Advertisement

New postal stationery with advertisement is sold only through **Bangalore, Chennai, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai and Sansad Marg (New Delhi)** bureaux on the day of release, and can be supplied through PD Accounts opened at these designated bureaux. Domestic PDA holders obtain these items by placing demands with the bureau where their accounts stand.

82. Distance Learning Package

The Department provides "**Distance Learning Philately**" at its Postal Training Centres and the Postal Staff College of India, Ghaziabad, to equip philately personnel with knowledge of the hobby, the products/services and marketing skills. The course comprises **study material, a questionnaire and project work**. The course formulated by the Postal Training Centre, Mysore is quite popular.

NOTE — INSTITUTION NAME

The apex training institution earlier called the Postal Staff College of India (PSCI), Ghaziabad, is now the **Rafi Ahmed Kidwai National Postal Academy (RAKNPA), Ghaziabad**. The substance of the distance-learning facility is unchanged; only the institution's name has been updated over time.

83. Compact Disk on Philately

The Department has provided **CDs on Philately** giving an overview of Indian philately — the hobby, the products/services, theme-wise lists of stamps and their scanned images. Kolkata GPO and the Andhra Pradesh Circle (Hyderabad) prepared the CDs, sold at all philatelic bureaux.

NOTE — MEDIUM SUPERSEDED

Physical CDs are now largely superseded by online/digital resources on the India Post philately portal. Treat this rule as historical; the current medium is the online portal.

84. Bibliography

Some standard reference books on philately that may be retained by bureaux/counters:

S.No.	Name of the Book	Author
1	Stamp Collection for Beginners	Rakesh Walia
2	Stamp Collecting	Manoharlal Chowdhary
3	A Guide to Stamp Collection, Part I	M. S. Bhaskaran Nair
4	Phil India	Manik Jain
5	Specialised Catalogue of Modern Indian Stamps	Dr. S. P. Gupta

S.No.	Name of the Book	Author
6	How to Arrange and Write up a Stamp Collection	Stanley Phillips & C. P. Rang
7	A Survey of Birds through Philately	A. V. Radha Krishnan
8	Sports	Dinesh Chandra Sharma (Institute of Philately)
9	Mahatma Gandhi (A Numismatic and Philatelic Study)	Dr. S. K. Bhatt
10	The Stamp of Truth (Mahatma Gandhi's Quotations)	Suresh Dalal
11	Priced Guide to Philatelic Literature	—
12	An Introduction to India used abroad	V. S. Dastur
13	The Philatelic Societies Year Book (1953–54)	The British Phil Association
14	Philatelic articles published in vernacular press (1994–1997)	Dinesh Mistry
15	India's Freedom Struggle through India Postage Stamp	Mr. V. S. Saksena
16	Who's Who on Indian Stamps	Sushma Suresh
17	A Drive to Promote Philately through Govt. Publication & Press	Dinesh Mistry

84-A. Deen Dayal SPARSH Yojana — philately promotion scheme (current)

Deen Dayal SPARSH Yojana (SPARSH = *Scholarship for Promotion of Aptitude & Research in Stamps as a Hobby*) is a pan-India scholarship of the Department of Posts to promote philately among school children. It was **launched on 3 November 2017**.

- **Eligibility:** students of **Classes VI to IX** in a recognised school in India, with a good academic record (usually at least **60%** in the last exam, with relaxation for SC/ST), who pursue philately as a hobby. The school should have a **Philately Club** and the candidate be a member; if there is no club, a student with his/her own **Philately Deposit Account** may be considered.
- **Scholarship amount:** **Rs. 6,000 per annum** per awardee (Rs. 500 per month), paid **quarterly** into the awardee's account with **India Post Payments Bank / Post Office Savings Bank**.
- **Number:** each Postal Circle awards up to **40** scholarships (about 10 per class, VI–IX).

- **Selection:** based on a **Philately Project** and a **Philately Quiz** conducted by the Circles, evaluated by a committee of postal officials and renowned philatelists.

UPDATE — ADDED, VERIFIED AS ON 21 JULY 2025

Added as a current, examinable philately-promotion scheme not present in the original handbook. Launch date (3 Nov 2017) and scheme parameters are per Department of Posts / PIB releases. Scholarship value and numbers can be revised — confirm the year's notification on the India Post philately pages.



Chapter IX — The Laws of the Land

85. Tax on Sale of Philatelic Items

As originally written: Sales Tax in India was charged at two levels — Local (sales within a state) and Central (inter-state), the Central Sales Tax being charged **in addition** to Local Sales Tax. Sales-tax laws did not mention philatelic items specifically, but applied to all sales except those specifically exempted by a notice.

UPDATE — SALES TAX REPLACED BY GST (W.E.F. 1 JUL 2017)

This position has fundamentally changed. Local Sales Tax/VAT and the **Central Sales Tax** on goods have been **subsumed into the Goods and Services Tax (GST)** with effect from **1 July 2017** (following the 101st Constitutional Amendment and the CGST/IGST/SGST Acts, 2017). The two-tier 'Local + Central Sales Tax' framework described above no longer operates for the sale of goods.

For philatelic items: postage stamps of **current/new issue** used to pre-pay postage are essentially the price of a postal service and are classified under HS heading **4907** (treated akin to money/actionable value, not taxed on face value). **Collectible** philatelic items (used or non-current stamps, first-day covers, postal stationery, etc.) fall under HS heading **9704**.

Confirm the **exact GST rate/exemption** applicable to a given item against the current **CBIC rate notification**, as GST rates are revised from time to time. (This Handbook does not state a specific rate to avoid quoting a figure that may be superseded.)

86. Import & Export

(a) Commodity Classification for Imports

The **8-digit** commodity classification for imports was adopted from **1 April 2002**. The relevant codes for philatelic items are:

Code	Description
4907 00 10	Indian unused postage, revenue or similar stamps, including stamp-impressed paper, of current or new issue
9704 00 10	Postage or revenue stamps, used or unused
9704 00 20	Stamp-post marks, first-day covers, used or unused
9704 00 90	Postal stationery (stamped paper) and the like, used or unused
9704 00 90	Philatelic accessories

(b) Import

Import is **free** for stamps other than those under heading **4907 00 10**. Import of items under **4907 00 10** is **restricted** — a specific permit/licence from the **Director General of Foreign Trade (DGFT)** is required.

(c) Custom Tariff

There is **no customs duty** on stamps other than those under heading **4907 00 10**, on which it was charged at **25% of the face value**.

UPDATE — VERIFY CURRENT CUSTOMS FIGURE

The ITC(HS) heading structure (4907 / 9704) broadly continues under the current tariff. However, the '**25% of face value**' **customs-duty figure** and the precise 8-digit sub-headings should be **confirmed against the current Customs Tariff / DGFT ITC(HS) schedule**, because customs rates are revised through the annual Finance Act and DGFT notifications. This figure could not be independently confirmed as still current from a primary customs source and should be verified before being relied upon.

(d) Export

There are **no restrictions** on the export of stamps that are **less than 100 years old**.

(e) The Antiquities & Art Treasures Act, 1972 (52 of 1972)

Under this Act, an "**antiquity**" includes any coin, sculpture, painting, epigraph or other work of art/craftsmanship; any article detached from a building or cave; any article illustrative of science, art, crafts, literature, religion, customs, morals or politics of **bygone ages**; and any article of historical interest — which has been **in existence for not less than one hundred years**. It also includes any manuscript, record or document of scientific/historical/literary/aesthetic value **in existence for not less than seventy-five years**.

Registration of the following is **compulsory**: sculptures in stone, terracotta, metals, ivory and bone; paintings (including miniatures and *thankas*) in all media (paper, wood, cloth, silk, etc.); and manuscripts containing paintings, illustrations or illuminations. The **Director General of the Archaeological Survey of India** is competent to issue a permit under Section 3 for the export of any antiquity/art treasure.

UPDATE — ACT CONFIRMED IN FORCE

The Antiquities and Art Treasures Act, 1972 (Act 52 of 1972, in force from 5 April 1976) **remains the governing law**, administered by the Archaeological Survey of India under the Ministry of Culture. The thresholds are unchanged — antiquity = at least **100 years** old; manuscripts/records

= at least **75 years** old. A replacement Bill has been discussed in the past but has **not been enacted** as of this update, so the 1972 Act continues to apply. (Source: Act 52 of 1972; ASI / Ministry of Culture.)

End of Handbook

This concludes the updated *Handbook on Philately*. For any figure marked as subject to revision, always cross-check the latest Directorate circular or the India Post philately portal before relying on it.

COLOPHON

Prepared by **Dak Guru — A Self-Learning Portal** (www.dakguru.com) as a study aid for LDCE IP / PS Group 'B' aspirants. Statutory position verified as on July 2026. In case of any conflict, the original rule, order or gazette notification prevails.

